of the date, she tells me she has something to admit – she's 28, not 25. Nothing is a problem any more. My mind is made up.

Later in the series, with our communication becoming more constant and texts not even needing looking over by Gareth Batty any more, the team go to the Wellington Bar in Knightsbridge. 'You should invite Daniella,' he says, maybe put out that he is no longer required but now invested in this relationship that clearly already means so much to me. We are at the door and are told it's 20 quid each. We are cricketers without whites, looking for change. It's like our superpower has gone, suddenly reduced, the agency we hold inside our world diminished, rushed back in time to people who did things like lose tickets for James on the X43 on the way into Manchester. We are rummaging around in our pockets, pulling at handfuls of coins and notes. As we do so, Daniella walks straight past and straight in, saying hi to me as she does. Everyone seems to know who she is. It is like she glides, floating past me and the bouncers, waving at her with a handful of loose change. By the time I go to her house in London for the first time, I've told Marcus Trescothick again a few times, him morphing from a legendary opening bat to a relationship confidant, that I really do like her, that I think I was right, that this is going to be very serious. I get in her car and, as she turns on the ignition, the music she has been playing last turns on. It's the first Kasabian album – the same and only record I've been playing throughout this summer too. I think to myself, *OK, it's a sign; this is meant to be*.

There is a natural thing that is happening with Daniella, something I haven't experienced before with another person. I'm not trying too hard, shifting around, watching warily and working out who I need to be in her presence. I just feel comfortable. She understands my jokes, I understand hers. I find myself deeply and genuinely interested in everything she says. She is endlessly fascinating to me. Better still, she doesn't know anything at all about cricket. She has had her own career, her own life, an incredible story completely of its own. She has done so much already. I feel like mine has been so narrow in comparison. It is like there are no limits to who I can be with her, at the same time sensing, in some sort of subconscious way, that she is seeing who I am and also showing me, just by being in her presence, what life could be like next. She can see the boy on the bench, almost like she is there at that time, talking to me and telling me what the